

Someone Who Cares - Game Design Document V2.15.0

Last updated: April 18th, 2026 by Celso

Platforms: Web Price: Free (freemium model under consideration) Age Rating: +16	Playtime: 3-5 hours (chapter 1) Planned Release - community version: Chapter 1 - Q3 2026 Chapter 2 - Q4 2026 Chapter 3 - Q1 2027 - Enhanced Version: Chapter 1,2,3 - Q4 2027 Engine/Framework: TBD. RenPy, or Godot, or TuesdayJS	Producers: Celso Bessa Story: Celso Bessa Pedagogic Lead: TBD Design Lead: TBD Programming Lead: Celso Bessa
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What is Someone To Care (Executive Pitch):

Andrea is a Colombian journalism student, unsure if journalism is her true calling, and interning in a small community newsroom. Her brother's disappearance during the Nov 23 2019 protest in Bogotá sparks her interest in investigative techniques that will help her gather initial evidence that will jump start an official investigation (Chapter 1) and eventually uncover the truth (Chapter 2). Andrea will learn to use OSINT techniques, evaluate evidence, interview sources, assess risks, research archives and libraries, and use web tools to advance her investigation. And under the tutelage of her supervisor, Andrea starts on a path that might expose much of what is invisible to, and within, her.

By the end of history, Andrea is older and successful as journalist and is teaching new journalists in an university (if we use voiceover/narration, this is the reason), and we learn what happens to her brother:

*Her brother and a friend, both students of political science and activists, became aware of criminal schemes and corruption regarding land grabbing and real state corruption related to the future Bogotá Metró. They draw attention of who start surveilling and tracking them. During the same protest where the student Dilan Cruz was killed, her brother and his friend were beaten by the police and tried to run. The criminals took the opportunity to corner and kidnap them. Her brother was killed, and she finds his remains by the end of chapter 1. By the end of chapter two, we learn what happened to her brother's friend. And by the end of chapter 3, we learn the reason behind the killings and who is the culprit. **In all chapters, her investigation leads to official investigation by the states and other positive impacts on the society.***

NB: this game is not about any specific case. Cases like the Dilan Cruz killing should be mentioned incidentally only, as part of news or resources referenced. We will strive to be utterly respectful of

the memories, and the pain, of real people.

The plot is yet to be fully developed, but the initial outline is further below this document.

Someone To Care is a hybrid of a visual novel and interactive learning guide (i.e., the guide) that uses storytelling to teach the learner (player) techniques found in the Exposing The Invisible (ETI) [workshop curricula](#) and the [educational kit](#), as well as in referenced resources and the [Digital Enquirer](#) resource. We will use a fictional story that extrapolates facts from Colombia's recent story to guide the player – regardless of their experiences with games and visual novels – in how to do advanced searches, interviews, evaluate evidence, and use interactive fictional websites and tools mockups mirroring real tools used on investigative OSINT-based journalism. As a result, to develop skills in a sandbox, a safer, and easier environment, to learn about real cases, how to find real resources (e.g., Forensic Architecture work on protests in Colombia), how to use tools, etc.

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Image 1

Image 2

The guide, whose target audience is journalists and citizen investigators looking for upskilling, is intended to be episodic, expandable, and modular. Every episode uses narrative elements and gameplay to go through one or two articles from the Exposing the Invisible curricula in-depth, while also presenting techniques from other articles and referenced resources, which might be further explored in other episodes. This format allows us to (1) be flexible in the breadth and depth of the content, the technical, visual, narrative, and educational choices according to availability of funds, time, and other resources and (2) adapt plot, story, and curricula according to the feedback from previous episodes.

The guide's graphic design, interaction models, and mechanics are mainly inspired by [visual novels](#), while also borrowing elements of story-rich CRPGs and [point-and-click adventure](#) games. Some titles that serve as inspiration or reference are [Hauma - A detective Noir story](#) (SenAm Games), [The Walking Dead](#) (Telltale Games), [1979 Revolution - Black Friday](#) (iNK Stories, N-Fusion Interactive), [The Silent Age](#) (House on Fire), [Her Story](#) (Sam Barlow), [The Wolf Among Us](#) (Telltale Games), [Inside](#) (Playdead), [Disco Elysium](#) (ZA/UM), and [What Remains of Edith Finch](#) (Giant Sparrow).

The project will be web-based and developed using open source tools and its art direction will be based on a conceptual art/draft-like visual style, which, besides being references to journalism (e.g., paper and pen annotations, post-it, and photojournalism), graphic novels and Colombia graffiti, allows for easier asset creation, using different references, models, sources, and techniques such as photographs and screenshots, short videos, physical and digital drawings, rotoscope, comic books, vector and raster graphics, interfaces, use different resolutions, levels of fidelity, etc., translating into lower costs and nimbleness. Because the guide is based on archetypical Colombian stories, we will make use of Colombia cultural elements for the project's art direction, character modeling/referencing, score, effects, acting, and voice work. Whenever feasible, we will work with Colombian artists and communities, ensuring its contextual relevance and community importance.

Chapter 1 will be a full and independent release, comprising 2 or 3 episodes, covering about 50% of the full plot and 25% of the ETI Kit. In this version, the dialogs are presented visually with in-game text, animations and score will be limited, tasks are simplified, stock sound effects will be used. Future expansions and remasterizations can build upon it and include voice-acting for dialogs, extend the use of animation, improve art-direction and plot, have custom sound effects and score, etc. And hypothetical remakes could lean towards completely point-and-click adventures or even space-exploration oriented adventure with isometric or 3d-isometric like graphics such as Disco Elysium or Syndicate.

Unique Selling Points:

- Real-world events and the use of real investigative journalism techniques allow for greater engagement.
- Interactive and storytelling-based learning allow "real-world hands-on" skill building in a safer context.
- The Reuse of content creates added value to the ETI Kit.

Player Objectives:

- To build and gain confidence in using investigative journalism skills through simulation of techniques actually used in investigations.
- To develop psychological resilience through role-playing events based on real-world events.

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|--|---|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> Emotional story and plot allow reflection and catharsis, with potential to be inspiring for new and potential investigators, and to be reaffirming to the more experienced ones. | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> To learn about and use high-value 3rd party resources and tools for investigations. |
|--|---|

Design and Experience Pillars -

[Consider using the to the 14 forms of fun framework](#)

Pillar 1	Pillar 2	Pillar 3

Audience and Market

Narrative - Story and plot:

Plot Outline

(the outline below could be outdated. Please, refer to the document [TT] Someone who cares - Story and Plot for the full and updated story and plotline.)

- **Chapter 1 - Someone who cares**
 - In a (false) Comfort zone
 - Introduce our character and her world, while also introducing the guide's interface and its controls.
 - Andrea dreams about the first time her brother and she visited Bogotá, while kids. Suddenly, she is an adult, and his brother is still a kid and she loses her in a Bogotá crowd. She wakes up with a message from her supervisor telling her to get to the office before everyone else.
 - Andrea rushes to the office, but sleepy, is mugged while walking in search of a taxi.
 - Pedagogic and story beat: basic digital and holistic safety, having a protocol for when the worst happens, keeping herself safe, data backup, etc.
 - Colombia's context in 2019/2020 (Colombia life, pandemics, social arrest).
 - Andrea's status quo in 2019 (unsure of her place, difficulties in paying for the university, traditional family values clashing with her life, apolitical).
 - **Emotional Core: Family**
 - Her mother sees her as responsible for the care of her brother and she feels she has always been overlooked by her mother in relation to her brother.
 - Goals:
 - Chapter 1:

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- Find her beloved brother / solve his disappearance
 - Get her mother approval and respect
- Chapter 2:
 - Learn the truth about this death
 - Overcome her need for approval, being self-confident and generous with herself.
- Conflicts:
 - Unsure of what want to do with her life, including career
 - Feels a little bit guilty about her brother's disappearance and her rage/despite because of him being favorited by her mother
 - Too sensitive to mother issues
 - Worry too much about other people's opinion
- Desire(s)
 - She wants to find her place in the world, in her family, and in the society she lives in.
 - She wants to find or learn what happened to her brother. In this specific chapter, to find someone to care enough in the state to effectively pursue an official investigation.
- Unfamiliar Situation
 - Social unrest in Colombia.
 - Police repression during protest.
 - November 23, 2019 protest: her brother disappears
 - She feels guilty, and her mother resents her.
- Adapt (**this is the bulk of the game/guide**)
 - *The community network where she works doesn't have enough resources to do a full investigation.*
 - *She needs to gain investigative skills.*
(*Series of tutorials disguised as story/plot beats, interactive challenges, and tasks, mapped to some of ETI Kit chapters as described below*).
 - *She needs to grow emotionally and find balance in her role in her family.*
 - Asking for help from the supervisor.
 - *Her supervisor tells her she has a confidential source as an officer, in the Procuraduría General de La Nación (Office of the Inspector General of Colombia) that might help, but she needs some good evidence to convince the source.*
 - *Supervisor lays out the learning/investigation path, tasks, and shares advice.*
 - Gaining kills
 - *Creating a plan.*
 - *Investigating - a series of "hands-on" tasks, tutorials and challenges*
 - *Field 1: familiarize with location, look for witnesses and evidences.*
 - *Interviews*
 - *Tips from ____*
 - *Creating rapport with a source*
 - *Truth hides: Confronting the realities of investigating (e.g., not everyone is willing to talk, state bureaucracy, lack of resources, harassment, etc).*
 - *How to investigate during a pandemic*
 - **Field 2 [high stakes; high risks]**
 - **Harrasers, Police, Criminals, Lockdown**
 - **OSINT**

- **WebArchive**
 - **Dorking**
 - **Geolocation**
- Getting what is desired
 - Andrea gathers enough information and source is convinced to open the case
 - We come back from the flashback and learn that the source was able to open the case, but its outcome is uncertain and depends on new and stronger evidence. For Andrea, finding someone that cares is a success, and she is confident justice will prevail
- Paying a heavy price for winning
 - Grief, exhaustion
- A return to a familiar situation
 - Family is family.
 - She (partially) reconciles with her mother, who praises her effort and talent, and she comes to terms with her guilt and understands she wasn't her brother's guardian. Some doubts about "justice will prevail" in the back of her head, but she is now confident she has the skills and strength to fight for justice.
- **Chapter 2 - Someone we care**
 - In a (false) Comfort zone
 - Around two years later, the world is still fighting a pandemic, Colombia is still struggling with violence, political unrest, during an election year. Because of the pandemics, bureaucracy, political disinterest and the challenges brought by the pandemics, the investigation around Andrea's brother is stale.
 - Quick reintroduction to our character and her world, while also introducing the guide's interface and its controls.
 - "Come see me." (again)
 - Andrea's supervisor left another puzzle on top of her desk. The puzzle answer indicates where she will meet her supervisor.
 - The scene leads to a flashback. We will stay on it for most of this story.
 - Colombia's context in 2021/2022 (Colombia life, pandemics, social arrest).
 - Andrea's status quo in 2022 (still with difficulties in paying for the university, grief, disillusioned with the state of the official investigation, mentally exhausted,).
 - Emotional Core: Family
 - She feels like her mother still sees her as responsible for the care of her brother (but in the end, we will learn that isn't the case).
 - She feel helpless, without any real agency in pushing the investigation forward
 - Desire
 - She wants to reconnect with her mother
 - She wants to find or learn what happened to her brother. In this specific chapter, the intermediary goals are (1) gather further information/evidence and (2) gather public support to press authorities
 - Unfamiliar Situation
 - Official investigation is stale (pandemics, bureaucracy, political disinterest and the challenges brought by the pandemics)
 - Economical distress
 - Social unrest in Colombia increases.
 - Police and criminal violence.
 - *Adapt (this is the bulk of the game/guide) - Investigation is in stale state*

- *Truth hides 2: Confronting the realities of investigating (e.g., not everyone is willing to talk, state bureaucracy, lack of resources, harassment, etc).*
 - *Another series of "hands-on" tasks, tutorials, and challenges here.*
- *A smearing campaign against her brother*
 - *Another series of "hands-on" tasks, tutorials, and challenges here.*
- *Conflict waits in every corner / Fighting (bureaucracy) Mastodons*
 - *Another series of "hands-on" tasks, tutorials, and challenges here.*
- *Finding allies*
 - *Allies on investigation: a tech lab (e.g. [Fundación Karisma Tech lab](#)), a data analysis and visualization team (e.g. [DataSketch](#)), or a Forensic Architecture-like organization, another [investigative journalism outlet](#), mainstream media, etc*
 - *Allies for legal action (something like [Dejusticia](#), [ILEX](#) or [ISUR](#))*
 - *Allies on campaigning (something like [Dejusticia](#), [CeroSetenta](#), etc)*
- *A clearer view: Andrea finds a few more pieces (of the puzzle).*
- *Unexpected help.*
- *Facing demons (emotional climax)*
 - *Winning over fear and helplessness.*
 - *Fully overcoming guilt.*
- Getting what is desired
 - She concludes her investigation, learns her brother's fate, finds his remains and clears his name: He was killed for doing something honorable.
- Paying a heavy price for winning
 - Some bitterness and cynicism, loss of innocence. She is now known as a talented and respected investigator, but in society like Colombia, this brings some danger.
- A return to a familiar situation
 - Family is family, is family (catharsis).
 - She completely reconciles with her mother.
 - We come back from the flashback and learn that she is almost finished with her graduation as a journalist. Like most of us, she sometimes still feels not sure of her place in the world, but her brother's name is cleared, her family had some closure (albeit inherently insufficient), and now she has some wisdom and is confident in her calling, and will either find, or create, her place in the world.

The following sequence of ETI resources is planned to guide the plot, the tasks, and skills to be developed through it:

- [You Are Already an Investigator](#)
- [Safety First!](#)
- [What Makes an Investigation](#)
- [Evaluating Evidence and Information Sources](#)
- [Get Your Facts Straight: The Basics of Fact-Checking](#)
- [Investigation is Collaboration: How to Make It Work](#)
- [Retrieving and Archiving Information from Websites](#)
- [OSINT – Diving into an ‘Ocean’ of Information](#)
- [Geolocation Methods: A step by step guide](#)

Third-party content and tools planned to be used or referenced include (non-exhaustive list):

- Forensic Architecture Investigation on the death of Dilan Cruz
 - <https://forensic-architecture.org/investigation/the-killing-of-dilan-cruz>

- DuckDuckGo, Google, Bing and other search engines
- Web Archive
- Google Maps
- Signal
- Protonmail
- Several OSINT tools
- Other tools from the base ETI articles and content from the Digital Enquirer resource.

NB: the extended story, plot and the correspondent story and pedagogic beats mapping are being developed in a specific document at

<https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1W5n1r2zmGA6c7Ff691UnL-T37HpAW65T/>

Core Gameplay and Mechanics:

As mentioned above, the guide's graphic design, interaction models, and mechanics are mainly inspired by [visual novels](#), while also borrowing elements of story-rich CRPGs and [point-and-click adventure](#) games. As such, we will use chapters, scenes, and panels (as in comic book panels) as logical and narrative units. A chapter consists of scenes that move the story, the plot, or the training forward. Scenes, which would be equivalent to game levels, might have one or more panels evoking graphic novels/comics panels, newspaper articles and magazine articles.

The learner will follow the story and at certain points will be presented with several interaction options to move the story forward

- Prompts for choosing dialog/action/interaction options
- Scenarios and props to explore, find, and use with scenes (e.g., mobile phone, computers, browsers, software).
- Tasks to be executed both within the guide and elsewhere. For example, on the ETI Kit, WebArchive, Google Maps, etc.
- Quick time events

NB: the amount and complexity of activities and mechanics will vary depending on resources available, timelines, deadlines, etc. Chapter 1 - Community Version, will be less complex and more learning task oriented.

As much as possible, activities should move both plot forward and teach something to the players/learners, be it in a conscious and obvious way (e.g., how to use web archive, how to measure something in Google Earth) or on a subconscious level (e.g., being careful with words, using a safer instant messenger). We are considering an "annotated" mode in future re-releases. An optional mode in which the player will see more non-diegetic notes, hints, references, etc.

Controls

TBD

Basic Loop

Balance and Pacing

Setting & World

Character Design

Work in progress

Tone & Aesthetics

Work in progress

Basic Palette

Work in progress

Quick References

Reference/concept 1	Reference/concept 2

Technical Aspects

The project will be web-based and developed either (a) RenPy, or B) using the Godot game engine, which uses C++, C# and GDScript but publishes HTML5+CSS+Javascript packages. The activities can be executed by using a mouse/touchpad and a keyboard, and we will strive to make the guide friendly to assistive technologies. In fact, support for assistive technology and accessibility techniques will be one of the main guidelines for choosing the framework.

Business Model

Tentative Project Timeline

- Chapter 1 - Community Version:
 - February 2024 - Project Kick off
 - 20/02: Kick-off meeting (concluded)
 - Idea maturing / discussions with Tactical and Tech and possibly other stakeholders (in progress)
 - March 2024 - Pre production
 - Project's "bible" writing
 - Conceptual art
 - April 2024 - Pre-Production
 - Scriptwriting (plot, story, pedagogic program elements)
 - Technical Trials

- May 2024 - Production
 - Main development (visual/graphic design and programming)
- June 2024 - Post-production
 - Demo release
 - Q&A
 - Testing
 - Debugging
- July 2024 - Release
 - soft release
 - Hard release
- August 2024 - Initial Support
 - Initial User support

- Chapter 2
 - TBD

Budget

Chapter 1 - Community Version.

Detailed budget in the Annex 1 ETI Interactive Learning Guide budget

Budget (minimum wage rate)	Eur
292 person-hours	3623.72
Scriptwriting session travel (from Morocco)	330
Scriptwriting session lodging (2 nights)	120
Administrative Costs (5%)	203.69
Total Before Taxes	4277.41
Taxes (25%)	1069.35
Total After Taxes	5346.76

Person-Hours Breakdown

Activity	Hours	EUR (normal rate)	EUR (minimum wage)
<i>Idea maturing / discussions with Tactical and Tech and possibly other stakeholders (in progress)</i>	8	221.76	99.28
<i>Project's "bible" writing</i>	16	443.52	198.56
<i>Conceptual art</i>	40	1108.8	496.4
<i>Scriptwriting (plot, story, pedagogic program elements)</i>	32	887.04	397.12
<i>Main development (visual/graphic design and programming)</i>	80	2217.6	992.8
<i>Demo release</i>	8	221.76	99.28
<i>Q&A / Testing</i>	40	1108.8	496.4

Debugging	32	887.04	397.12
Release (soft and hard release)	16	443.52	198.56
Support (first month)	20	554.4	248.2
Total	292	8094.24	3623.72

Annex 1 - Visual Reference and mood board art

In addition to the 3rd party images below, Celso Bessa's images to be used as references for Colombian scenarios, props, and characters can be found at

<https://drive.proton.me/urls/9XJAG6T55W#Qn0PCgLXB4S2>

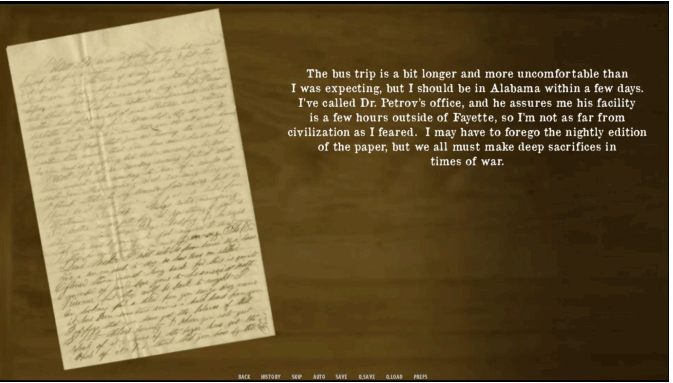
- Page 10: Hauma - Interface, genre, gameplay style and art direction main reference
- Page 11: Romancing Flesh - art direction, genre, gameplay, interface main reference
- Page 11: Tambó, by Ghetto Kumbé, music video - setting, tone, character design, social context main reference
- Page 12: L.S.D.S - art direction, genre, gameplay, interface
- Page 12: The Silent Age - gameplay style, interface, genre, art direction reference
- Page 13-14: Assorted references, *experiments and conceptual art*

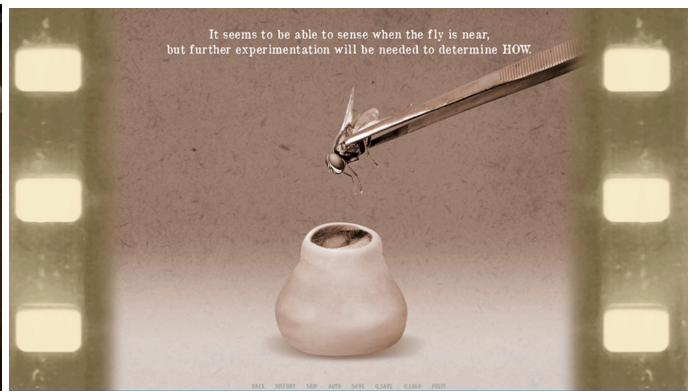
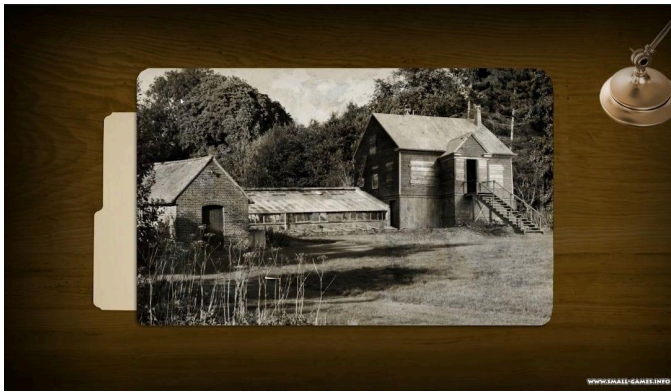
Hauma - Interface, genre, gameplay style and art direction reference



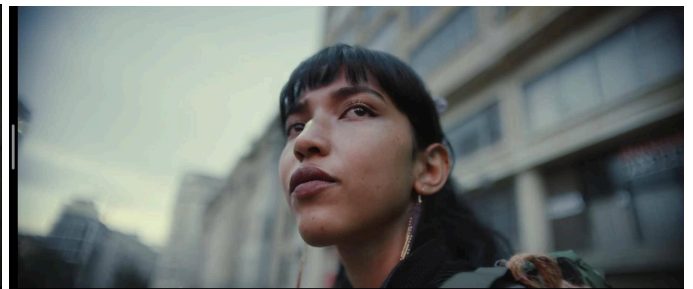


Romancing Flesh - art direction, genre, gameplay, interface

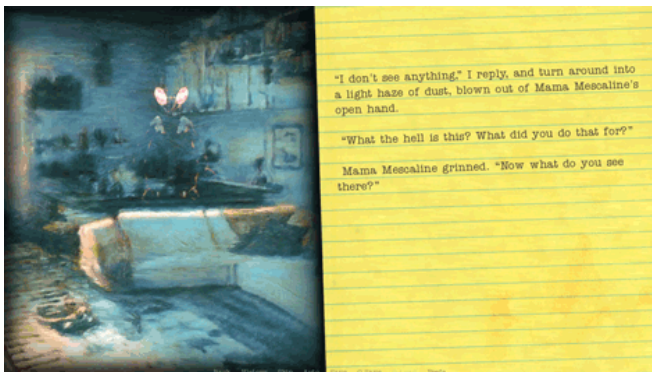




Tambó, by Ghetto Kumbé, music video - setting, tone, character design, social context



L.S.D.S - art direction, genre, gameplay, interface

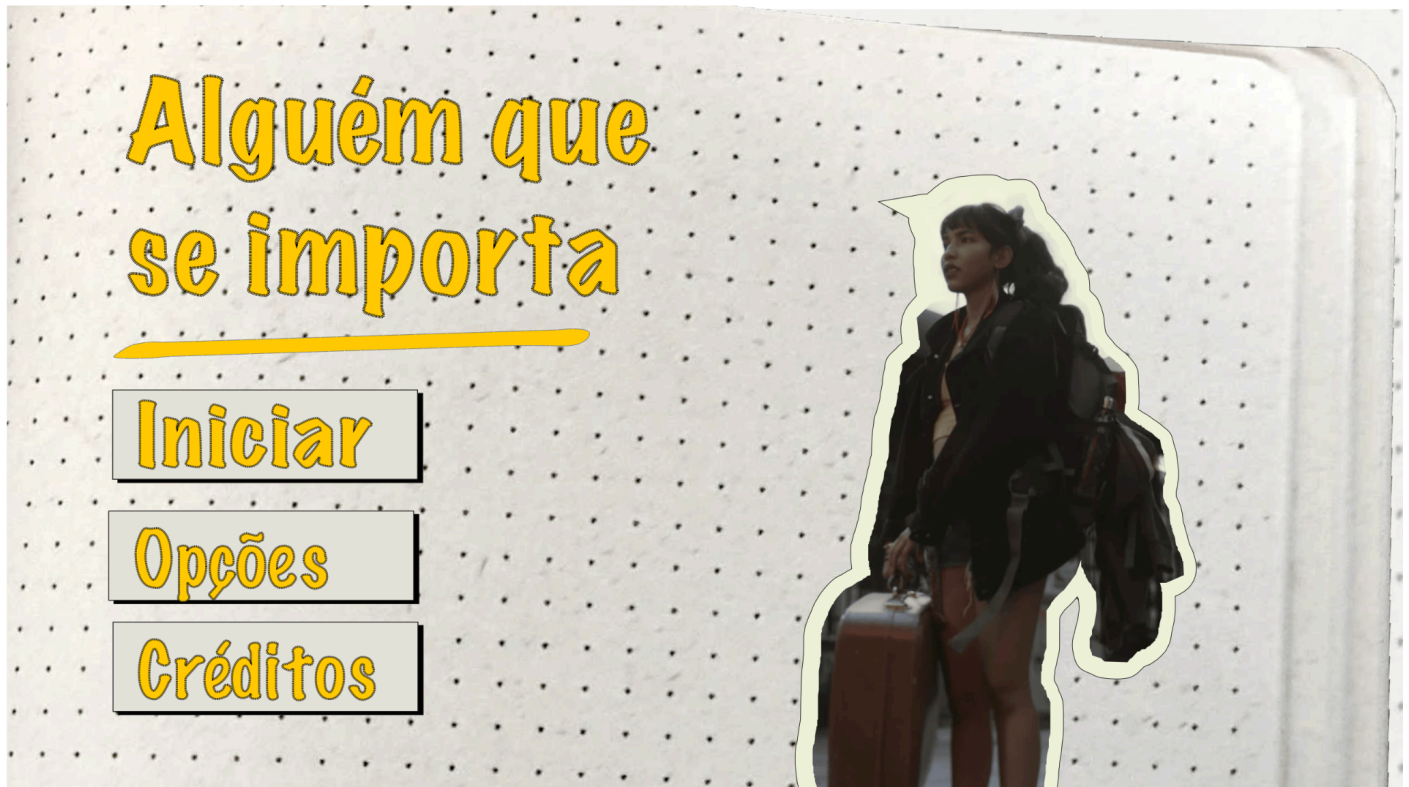


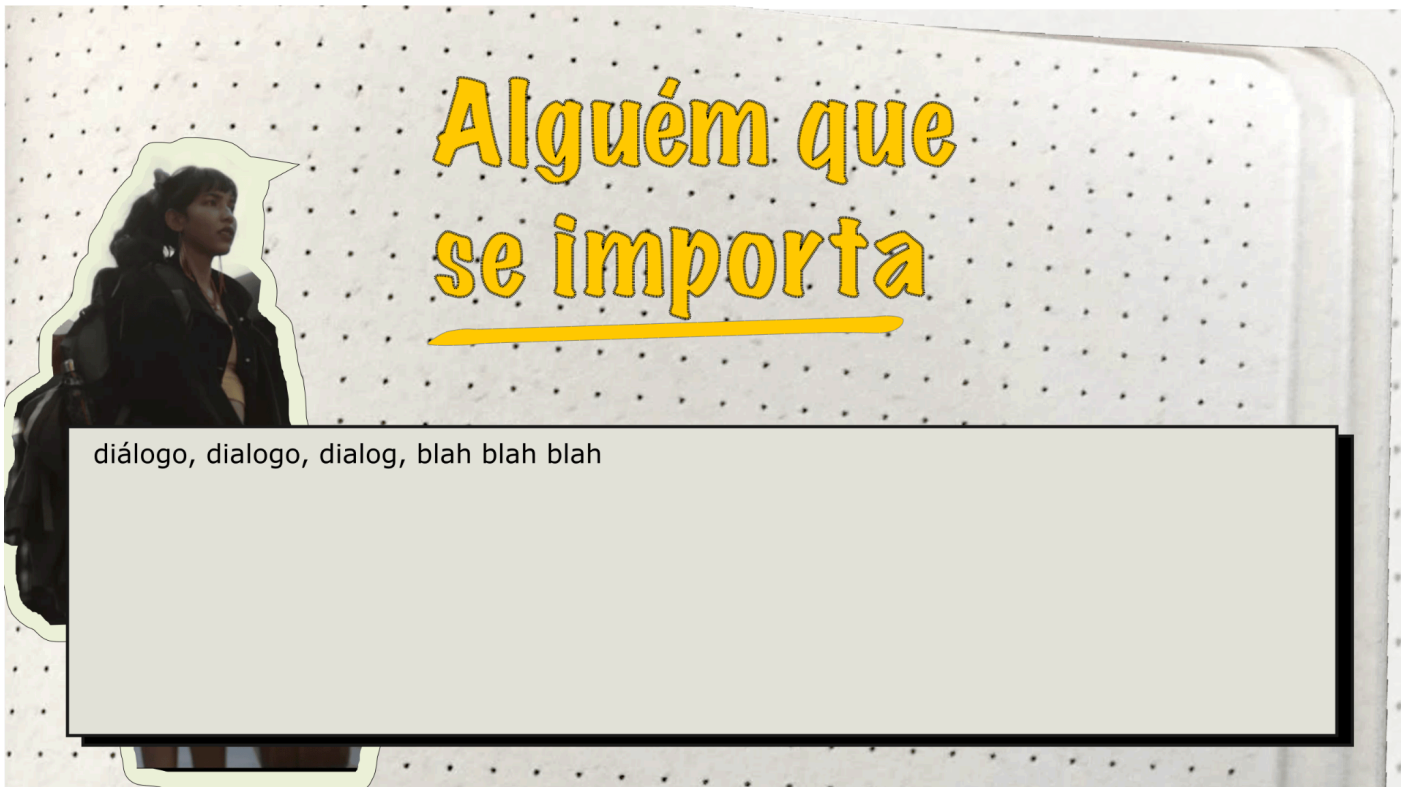


The Silent Age - gameplay style, interface, genre, art direction reference



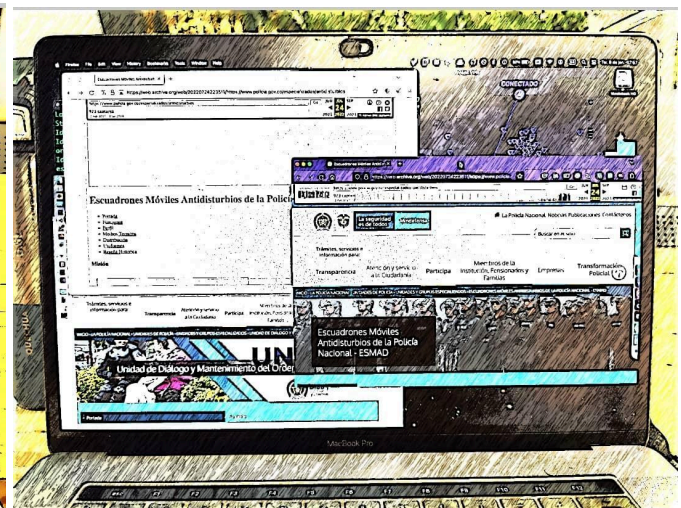
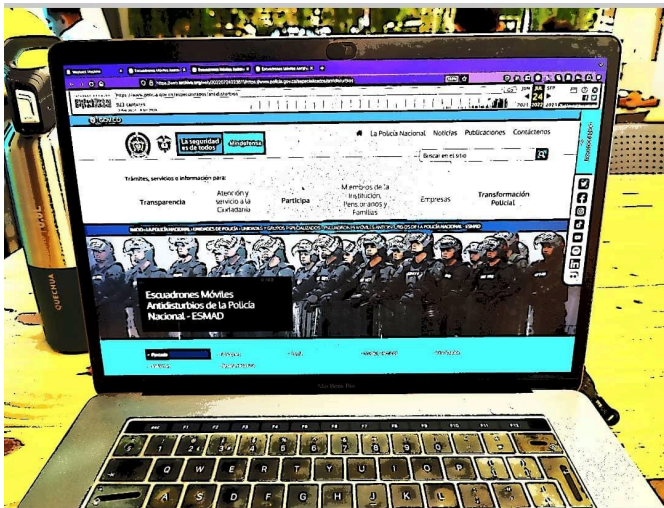
Assorted references, experiments and conceptual art

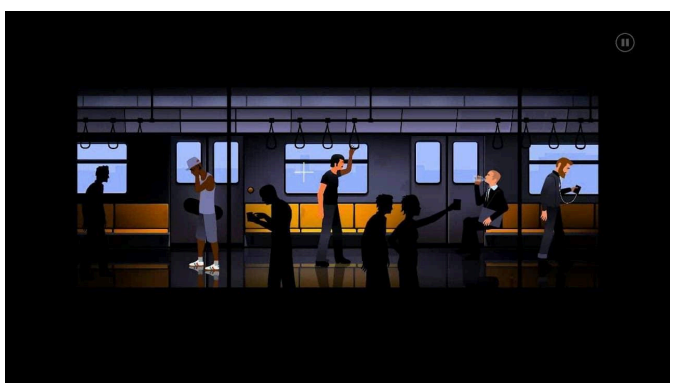
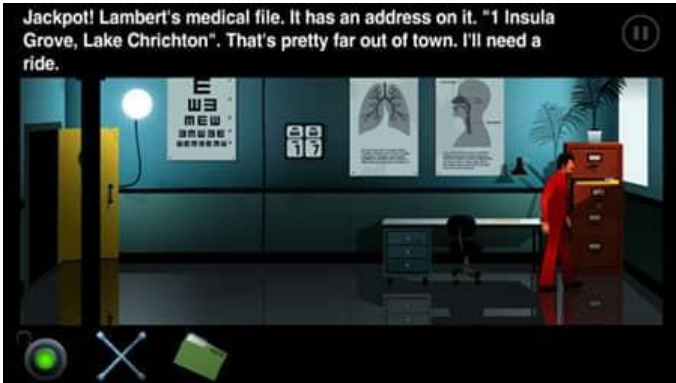
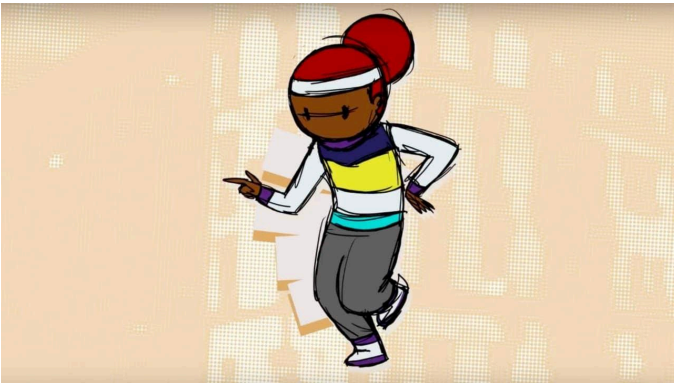
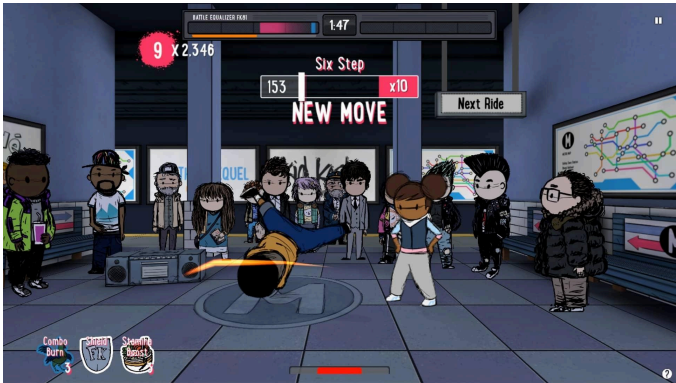
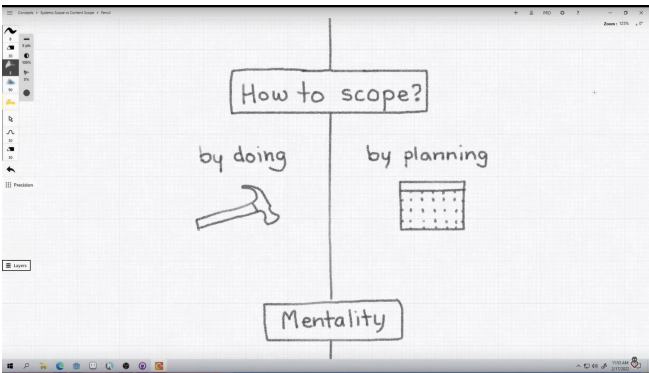
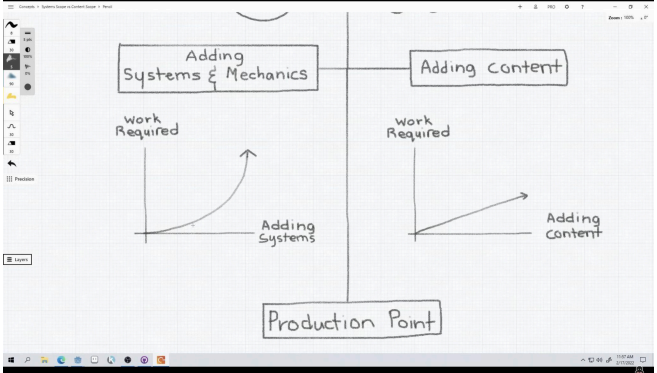
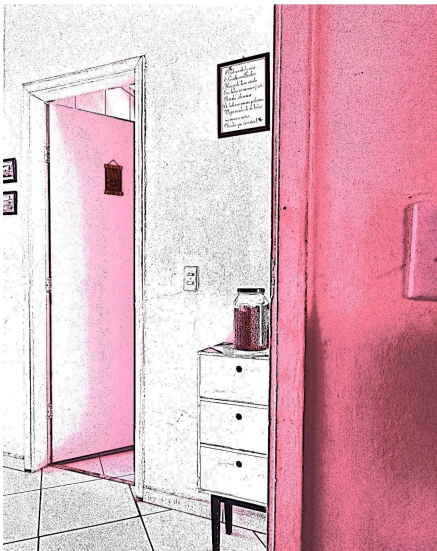




diálogo, dialogo, dialog, blah blah blah







Annex 2 - Music and Sound reference, mood playlist

▶ Asian Dub Fondation - Truth Hides

▶ Amenaza (Karaoke) - Systema Solar

▶ Que Diera

▶ Bulin 47 - Me Arregle (Audio Oficial)

▶ Los Vecinos - La Cumbia Soledaña

▶ La Yegros - Trocitos de Madera